Lesson Plan: Introduction Paragraph

Students will learn how to write an introduction that effectively prepares the reader for their thesis statement.

STUDENTS WILL…

- Review their thesis statements
- Understand how an introduction functions
- Learn different introduction styles
- Begin writing their introductions

MATERIALS NEEDED

Slide deck · Student laptops/chromebooks and access to yawp.school

Optional Opening: Review

1. Review assessment questions about critical essays. Ask the class first, then reveal the answer on the next slide.

   SLIDES 2–9

Opening Activity: General to Specific

1. Using the slides, have students place terms/sentences in order. You can have students work individually or as groups, depending on the class. [Note: the instructions are deliberately vague here. The goal is for students to figure out the order, which is most general to most specific (or vice versa), but don't tell them this in your directions.]

   SLIDES 10, 12

2. Have students report on the correct answers, and reveal these on the slides. Ask them how they came to their conclusions. What relationship or order is being used here? (Answer: big-to-small; general-to-specific)

   SLIDES 11, 13

The Lesson

1. At this point, most students should have a working thesis statement. **Celebrate this fact:** it's a major milestone in their essay writing process. It may be useful to check in with students or have them share their thesis statements out loud/with a partner. This helps them understand, own, and commit to their thesis statement, which they'll be spending a lot of time with.

   SLIDE 14

2. More importantly, now that they have a thesis statement, they can actually begin writing their essays!

3. Today we will focus on writing an introduction. Using the slides, teach students the **4 types of introduction styles,** with examples.

   `SLIDES 15–21`

   a. Try to engage students in these example intros by considering some of the following:

      i. Make sure that students understand that they're going to write their own intros today. Sometimes raising the stakes in this way will encourage them to pay attention to the examples.

      ii. While it may make sense for you to read the first paragraph, you might call on students to read the examples of the different intro styles.

      iii. Comment or ask questions about the different styles.

      iv. Note in each example intro how the thesis statement is the final sentence of the paragraph.

      v. Pay special attention to how these paragraphs start somewhat generally and then become more specific (like the opening activity!) until you're ready to drop the thesis statement at the end.

4. **Writing Activity:** Students write their own introductions.

   `SLIDES 22–23`

   a. Tell students that writing is decision making, and that this is one of those moments where they have to decide how they want to start their essays. With a story? A definition, quote, or question?

      i. Note: In formal, critical writing students are often told to avoid the first person pronoun "I." Decide on your policy here: depending on the topics, students may choose to start with a personal anecdote; in this case, it might be ok to use the pronoun "I."

   b. Students should hopefully be pretty active in writing their intros. As they do, they'll surely want immediate feedback from you as well as the YAWP! Tutor: work the room and stay as active as possible with this feedback.

Adapted from Brian Connell's lesson plan for the YAWP! Writing Program, with slide numbers for the new deck.